

ISMUN 4.0

BACKGROUND GUIDE



WORLD HEALTH ORGANISATION

Agenda: *Strengthening Global Surveillance Frameworks to Combat Substandard and Falsified Medical Products and Secure International Supply Chains*

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LETTER FROM THE EXECUTIVE

BOARD

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to the World Health Organisation (WHO)! We hope that your experience in the committee will be both enlightening and enjoyable allowing delegates to join debates and learn more about this important topic. We hope that you will leave the committee as global citizens who help further the unity of the world community.

As the executive board we are excited to see the perspectives, ideas and conversations that delegates will bring to the committee.

We look forward to seeing delegates all work together to create solutions that will achieve this goal during the conference. We also cannot stress enough how important it is for delegations to work together and cooperate. This is the foundation of the United Nations and a vital uniting block for any Model UN conference.

Finally do not forget to have fun!

A Model UN conference is unlike any public speaking or debating forum. Make the most of it. Take the chance to learn and make new friends that will last a lifetime. You are truly privileged to have these opportunities that help you grow as an individual and connect with people from, around the world.

We look forward to seeing delegates all grow in knowledge and make friends during the conference.

Kindest regards,

Chairperson

Bhavya Muttha

Vice Chairperson

Niteesh Bora

ABOUT THE COMMITTEE

The World Health Organization (WHO) is the agency within the United Nations system that deals with global health matters. It was established in 1948. Works with 194 member states. The WHO coordinates efforts to tackle health-related issues, including disease prevention and medical care. It helps countries strengthen their health systems so that all people can have health security. It also supports access, to quality medicines for everyone who needs them.

The main goal of the World Health Organization is to achieve the level of health possible for every person. To do this the organization creates plans and actions that countries can use. These strategies are designed to handle health problems that require an coordinated response.

What Does WHO Do?

WHO addresses a range of global health issues from:

- Building stronger health systems and making care easier to reach.
- Making medicines and vaccines easier to obtain.
- Stopping and managing. Pandemics.
- Dealing with health emergencies such as disease outbreaks and humanitarian crises.
- Boosting research and sharing health information.
- Setting health standards and helping countries follow them.
- Helping nations work together to solve health problems that cross borders.

The current global health landscape is tied to conflicts, climate change, international trade, migration, misinformation and disruptions, in supply chains. When a global health emergency happens in one country it can quickly spread to countries. Conflicts and humanitarian crises can also damage health systems cut off medical supplies and stop essential services.

1. WHO in the Modern World

The role of WHO has become particularly important in the context of numerous challenges for pandemic preparedness, emerging infectious diseases, climate-related health risks, shortages of essential medicines, and inequities in health care.

WHO thus serves as a respondent to health emergencies, but also as a forum for sharing information, building consensus, coordinating responses, and strengthening health systems.

2. How Does WHO Work?

WHO is an coordinating organization. It is not like an political group. Its power comes from working across countries using scientific knowledge, technical advice and working with Member States.

The World Health Assembly (WHA) is the decision-making group of WHO. All Member States are part of it. Work together to set the goals and rules of the Organization.

For MUN purposes delegates should therefore focus on:

- Knowing the health issue.
- Showing their countrys point of view. What is important, to their country.
- Suggesting solutions that can actually be done.
- Working with countries by talking and working together.
- Thinking about money putting plans into action and working with countries.

3. Why WHO Matters

Health challenges do not stop at borders. Diseases can spread across countries medicines rely on supply chains and health emergencies can disrupt economies, education, security and communities.

Your task is to ask: What can countries realistically do together to solve the problem? A successful WHO committee must encourage research, diplomacy, negotiation and practical solutions while keeping protection of health at the centre of every discussion.

INTRODUCTION TO THE AGENDA

The surveillance of products is an important part of modern healthcare. Every day millions of people around the world depend on medicines, vaccines, diagnostic tests and other medical products to prevent and treat diseases.. A serious global health problem arises when these medical products are substandard falsified or handled in the wrong way.

A substandard medical product is one that does not meet the required quality standards. A falsified medical product is a fake—its name, ingredients or origin are misrepresented on purpose. Both substandard and falsified products can fail to treat illness. They can hurt patients. Weaken trust in healthcare systems.

The problem gets worse because medical products often travel across borders. One product might have parts made in one country be assembled in another packaged in a third and move through more countries before it reaches a patient. This creates an complex international supply chain. If any part of this chain is weak it becomes easier for substandard or falsified products to enter the market.

More pharmacies, global trade, online marketplaces and complicated supply chains make it harder for authorities to find and stop products. Each country has rules, different tools and different levels of resources. A product that is flagged as risky in one country might already be in countries by the time anyone acts.

That is why global surveillance is so important. Surveillance means collecting, analyzing and sharing information about medical products to spot problems and respond quickly.

This kind of surveillance needs cooperation between governments, health regulators, customs, drug companies, doctors, nurses, laboratories and global groups, like the World Health Organization. Through teamwork can we protect patients and keep medical products safe.

The main problem this committee is facing is not about finding medicines that are not good quality. The real issue this committee is dealing with is how to create a system that can spot problems before they happen track products

through the supply chain share information fast between countries and keep medicines that are not safe from getting to patients.

People who are part of the meeting need to think about the differences, between countries that have resources and those that have fewer resources the costs involved with the technology how to share data and protect privacy what role the companies that make medicines should play how to control the borders how to handle medicines sold online and the importance of working together.

KEY DEFINITIONS

• Falsified Medical Products

Falsified Medical Products are items that look like medical products but are not genuine. They are created on purpose to trick people into believing that they are authentic. Falsified Medical Products can have the name and appearance as a real medicine from a real company.

• Surveillance Framework

Surveillance Framework is a set of rules, groups, methods and tools that are used to watch over and address an issue. For this plan the Surveillance Framework might involve:

- National medicine regulators
- Customs authorities
- Laboratories
- Pharmaceutical companies
- WHO
- Reporting systems
- Information-sharing mechanisms

• Traceability

Traceability is the ability to follow a product as it moves from one step to another. For example: Manufacturer → Distributor → Warehouse → Pharmacy → Patient. Traceability helps to find where a falsified medical product came from and where it might have gone next.

- **Supply Chain Security**

Supply Chain Security is about keeping the supply chain safe from dangers such as:

- Counterfeit or fake products
- Theft
- Movement
- Changing the product without permission
- Computer attacks
- Disruptions
- Ways of storing and moving the products

Falsified Medical Products

Falsified medical products are items that are deliberately made to look like something that they're not. Falsified medical products can pretend to be made by a company to contain an active ingredient or to come from an approved source, when none of these statements is true. Falsified medical products are not a mistake in manufacturing; they are a deliberate act of deception.

Falsified medical products can be medicines, vaccines, diagnostic tools and many other health items. Falsified medical products may hold the ingredient, an incorrect quantity, no active ingredient or even dangerous substances. Because of this patients may not get the treatment they need. Falsified medical products can cause treatment failure, health problems and in some cases antibiotic resistance. Falsified medical products also erode trust in health systems and honest drug makers.

Falsified medical products are more than a danger to patients. In war unrest, terrorism, emergencies or political chaos falsified medical products can be used as weapons against civilians, soldiers or health services. Bad people may use medical products to spread fear stop vital care take advantage of shortages or break trust in hospitals, vaccine programs and governments. Falsified medical products can turn a health risk into an global safety problem.

The risk that falsified products become weapons is especially high in wars. Health systems are. People rely on emergency drugs and aid. When a falsified medical product enters a distribution it can hurt more, than one patient. Falsified medical products can spread mistrust of medicines. Disrupt emergency care. That is why finding and watching for medical products must be part of health safety and crisis plans.

Because drugs cross borders it is hard to stop medical products. A falsified medical product may be made in one nation packed in another. Moved through countries before it reaches a patient. Many manufacturers, wholesalers, distributors and other middlemen can create chances for falsified medical products to be swapped, altered or slipped into the supply chain. Online and informal markets also raise this danger.

Secure International Supply Chains

A secure international medical supply chain is a system that allows medical products to cross borders while preserving their quality safety, authenticity and availability from the factory to the patient. Security is not about stopping theft or tampering. It also involves making sure that supply chain products are made correctly stored properly transported safely well documented monitored all the way and delivered through channels. The World Health Organization or WHO says that many steps in the supply chain—such as buying, storing, repackaging, relabelling, transporting and distributing—are places where risks can appear.

To protect supply chains close cooperation is needed between authorities, customs agencies, manufacturers, distributors, healthcare providers and international groups. Stronger inspection rules, documentation, methods to verify supply chain products, tracking systems and rapid sharing of information when something seems wrong are all parts of the system. The WHO says traceability systems help follow supply chain products from start to finish. This makes it easier to spot problems early and act quickly when supply chain issues arise.

Secure supply chains are especially important during wars and humanitarian crises. Borders can be hard to control. Normal supply networks can break down. Shortages can create gaps that fake or illegal suppliers try to fill. A strong international supply chain must keep working during emergencies. It must still deliver medicines while maintaining oversight and detection tools.

For the WHO international supply-chain security matters a lot. No single country can handle products alone. When one country finds a medicine the information may be key for another country where the same supply-chain product was made, shipped, sold or distributed. Working together helps countries stop products from slipping into supply chains in the place. It helps them find supply-chain products faster when they appear. It helps them respond in a way that does not cut off access, to medicines that people need.

Connection To The Agenda

The two ideas are closely linked. Fake medical products are the danger. Keeping supply lines safe is one of the best ways to fight that danger. A strong global monitoring system can help countries see medicines, share alerts and follow how these products move between countries. The WHO Global Surveillance and Monitoring System or GSMS helps national regulatory agencies share details about medicines that are suspected.

This issue goes beyond controlling medicines. It involves health, international trade, border security help for people in need national security and getting ready for conflicts. Countries need to think about how global monitoring systems can spot dangers stop medicines from being used on purpose to hurt people protect those who are most at risk and make sure real medicines are available during big global problems.

So the main challenge for countries is not just finding medicines after they have reached patients. It is also, about creating a system that stops them from going into places where they are used to cause harm shares information and works together between countries. This is important to keep medicines to people who need them.

CURRENT SITUATION

The issue of quality and fake (SF) products is still a public health problem around the world. The World Health Organization (WHO) says that one in ten medicines in poor and middle income countries are not good enough or are fake. WHO also says that countries spend about thirty point five billion US dollars every year on these products. This is not about medicines. Fake and poor quality items can also affect vaccines, testing products and other medical tools.

This problem is being reported in every part of the world. WHO says that up to two billion people do not have access to products. This creates situations where people might go to places that're not official or safe. I see that people often have no options. Long supply chains, many middlemen and the increase in drug sales have made it harder for officials to check every part of the journey from making to the patient.

New WHO data shows that the problem is still happening more than before. In 2025 one thousand and thirty reports of medical products were sent to WHO. Eighty three percent of those reports came from officials. During that time WHO improved its Global Surveillance and Monitoring System (GSMS). They added a version that works in languages and made it better for reporting on lab tests.

The problem is still happening in 2026. WHO sent alerts about products. These include JAKAVI (ruxolitinib) found in Iran, Russia and Turkey in June 2026 and fake DARZALEX (daratumumab) found in the Maldives and Mexico in July 2026. I worry that fake products can get to patients through paths. These examples show how fake products can move between countries and sometimes end up with patients through shops, local stores, hospitals or places that are not allowed.

At the moment countries have abilities to control and check medical products. I notice that many countries have trouble with their systems. WHO said in June 2026 that seventy percent of countries have weak or not systems to properly check medicines and vaccines. This difference in strength makes it easier for

problems to happen in the supply chain and makes it more important to work together and share information.

Another area that is becoming more important is tracking. WHO's work in 2025 on tracking products says that tracking systems can help officials follow products through the supply chain make monitoring and help find and respond to problems. Tracking alone can't stop products from getting into the market. That means it has to be used with rules, checking, action and working with countries. I believe tracking is important for keeping the supply chain safe.

The current situation is a problem with two parts: Countries need to protect people from products while also making sure that real medicines are available not too expensive and can move easily between countries. The main question, for everyone is how to make the world watch and work together better without making rules that could slow down getting important medical products of moving efficiently across borders. The central question, for the community is how to strengthen surveillance and cooperation without creating excessive regulatory barriers that could themselves delay access to essential medical products.

CASE STUDIES

1. The Gambia. Substandard Paediatric Medicines (2022)

In 2022 The Gambia reported cases of acute kidney injury among children. A WHO investigation found that four paediatric medicines were substandard. These cough and cold medicines contained levels of diethylene glycol (DEG) and ethylene glycol (EG). The medicines were made by a company in India and had reached the Gambian market.

Significance:

This event showed how a single failure in medicine quality can turn into an international public-health crisis once the products move across borders. It also showed why fast detection, lab testing, product recalls and communication between countries are so important.

WHO Response:

WHO issued a Medical Product Alert. It helped with the investigation. Asked for the affected medicines to be removed from the market. WHO also urged countries that might have received these products through international supply chains to watch more closely and take action.

2. West / Central Africa. Falsified Antimalarial Medicines

WHO has recorded incidents involving falsified antimalarial medicines in Cameroon, Ghana and Liberia. In one alert from 2014 none of the medicines really came from the companies named on their labels. Two of the samples had less than 2% of the correct active ingredient. These products were moving through both informal supply chains.

Significance:

This case shows that falsified medicines can travel through networks just as easily as illegal ones. For diseases like malaria fake medicines can cause treatment to fail and weaken health programs.

WHO Response:

WHO issued a Medical Product Alert and asked regulatory authorities to watch their supply chains more carefully. WHO also encouraged authorities to report any suspected products so information could be shared around the world.

3. Falsified OZEMPIC. Brazil, United Kingdom and United States (2023–2024)

WHO discovered three batches of OZEMPIC (semaglutide) in Brazil, the United Kingdom and the United States. These products were found in 2023. Had entered regulated supply chains. The real manufacturer confirmed that these medicines falsely claimed to be theirs.

Significance:

This case proves that falsified medicines are not found in weak or unregulated markets. Well-controlled markets like Brazil, the UK and the US can be targets. As supply chains grow global and online buying increases the risk rises.

WHO Response:

WHO used data from its Global Surveillance and Monitoring System (GSMS) to issue a Medical Product Alert. It advised regulators and healthcare workers to improve monitoring and asked them to report suspected cases.

4. Falsified JAKAVI. Iran, Russian Federation and Türkiye (2026)

In June 2026 WHO issued an alert three batches of falsified JAKAVI (ruxolitinib) found in Iran the Russian Federation and Türkiye. The medicines had been sold to patients via platforms and in at least one case through a pharmacy. One sample tested had no ingredient listed.

Significance:

This case shows how medical-product falsification is increasingly crossing national boundaries. A fake medicine can appear in countries and spread through digital channels and traditional stores making it hard for local regulators to keep up.

WHO Response:

WHO issued a Medical Product Alert. It recommended monitoring of supply chains and online markets. It also asked authorities to inform WHO immediately if they found the same products.

WHO RESPONSE MECHANISMS

1. Surveillance and Monitoring System (GSMS)

The WHO Global Surveillance and Monitoring System (GSMS) was set up to help detect, report and respond to falsified medical products. It lets WHO receive reports from countries connect points of contact spot new patterns and offer technical support during emergencies. This system is especially useful because a medical product found in one country may have passed through others before reaching patients.

2. WHO Medical Product Alerts

When WHO gets information about a serious threat it issues a Medical Product Alert. These alerts share details about products and suggest what actions national authorities healthcare professionals and others should take. The official alert system keeps records of incidents involving falsified medicines, including several alerts released in 2026.

3. WHO Member State Mechanism

The Member State Mechanism on Substandard and Falsified Medical Products gives countries a way to work together on prevention, detection and response. It supports sharing information, experiences and best practices. It also helps strengthen global efforts against these harmful products.

4. Strengthening National Regulatory Systems

WHO helps countries improve their regulatory agencies. This includes work on market surveillance, inspections, quality control and overall oversight. WHO understands that strong global monitoring depends on countries being able to find and investigate medicines within their own borders.

5. International Information-Sharing

A key part of WHO's strategy is quickly sharing information, between Member States. The GSMS allows WHO to link incidents and connect focal points. This helps countries respond to threats that may cross their borders.

IMPORTANT REGULATORY TERMS

1. National Regulatory Authority (NRA)

A **National Regulatory Authority** is a government body responsible for regulating medical products within a country.

It may oversee:

- Product approval
- Quality standards
- Manufacturing
- Inspections
- Safety monitoring
- Recalls

2. Quality Control

Quality control involves testing and checking medical products to ensure that they meet established standards for quality, safety and effectiveness.

3. Regulatory Harmonization

Regulatory harmonization means countries working toward compatible rules, standards and procedures for regulating medical products. This can make international cooperation and information-sharing easier.

EXAMPLE SOLUTIONS

1. Global Track-and-Trace System

Use QR codes, digital identifiers and other technologies to track medical products from manufacturer to patient and detect suspicious products.

2. Rapid International Alert System

Create faster information-sharing between countries when a substandard or falsified product is detected, allowing other nations to investigate and prevent its distribution.

3. Strengthened Testing & Border Controls

Expand regional pharmaceutical laboratories and improve cooperation between health regulators and customs authorities to test suspicious products and stop them from entering legitimate supply chains.

4. Capacity Building for Developing Countries

WHO and international partners could provide technical assistance, training, laboratory equipment and regulatory support to countries with weaker surveillance systems. This is particularly important because a global supply chain is only as secure as its weakest points.

CONCLUSION

Medical products that are good or fake are a danger not to individuals but also to the health of the entire world. When medical products move through countries before reaching patients any weak link in the supply chain can allow unsafe medical products to reach real markets. Pandemics, wars, disasters and medicine shortages can make these risks even greater.

Fixing this problem requires more than rules in each country. Working together across borders, monitoring, sharing information fast having labs, safe ways to transport medical products and new tools must all combine to find and stop problems. The World Health Organization helps countries cooperate and improve their handling of these issues in places that lack money or expertise.

The tools and rules used must also be easy to use, not too expensive and easy to reach. A real global plan must consider the needs of countries while ensuring that information, about dangers can be shared quickly and clearly.

The committee must not think about what to do after fake medical products are found. The main goal should be to build a system that stops problems before they happen finds them when they do tracks them and deals with them all along the supply chain.

In the end the goal is simple: to make sure every patient can trust that the medical products they receive are safe work well are real. Have good quality. The committee's job is to find how the world can turn this goal into a plan that works together and lasts for a time.

SOURCES FOR RESEARCH

- World Health Organization (WHO)
- WHO – Substandard and Falsified Medical Products
- WHO – Global Surveillance and Monitoring System
- WHO – Medical Product Alerts
- WHO – Member State Mechanism
- U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA)
- European Medicines Agency (EMA)
- UNODC – United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime
- INTERPOL – Pharmaceutical Crime
- India – Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO)
- India – Ministry of Health and Family Welfare
- World Trade Organization (WTO)

